



nutrition, and sports engineering. This will create a new sector and open up new job opportunities.

Secondly, good coaches must also reach the grassroots — they must reach every school. You asked me earlier how the number of medals will increase. This is how. Right now, children are not receiving the right guidance at the right time. Many reach the national level purely through their own hard work, and only then do they get full support. If they get this support from the beginning — if they get access to these facilities and coaching from childhood — then I believe the number will increase significantly, and our chances of winning medals will improve.

Last but not the least, sport requires specialised manpower in managerial positions. One such example is SAI's Administrative Cadre, which is evolving into a specialised bureaucracy trained to facilitate sport-specific requirements such as coach development, talent identification, event organisation, and infrastructure building.

India consistently ranks high in global doping violations, yet NADA's (National Anti-Doping Agency) budget remains modest at

₹22.3 crore. Is this sufficient, and what reforms are needed to address the doping crisis?

Reforms should include increased funding, enhanced testing, stricter enforcement, and closer alignment with international anti-doping practices. From WADA's (World Anti-Doping Agency) side, a lot of awareness programmes are being organised, and workshops are being conducted. Through this, we are trying to create maximum awareness among athletes and coaches.

How strong is India's bid for the 2036 Olympics and the 2030 Commonwealth Games? What factors are in India's favour?

I am fully confident that we will win the 2036 Olympics bid because of the visible development in the country and the efforts of our Prime Minister. The international goodwill of our government and the personal relationships that our Prime Minister maintains with leaders of other countries give us an advantage.

Our bid is also bolstered by improving infrastructure, strong public support, and governmental commitment. Success will depend on meeting international standards and presenting a comprehensive, well-planned proposal.

Correct vision: "I have put a proposal to our ministry that we should start expanding professional courses in sports science, as very few universities offer them right now" — Raksha Khadse. R.V. MOORTHY

What needs to be done over the next decade to achieve a top 10 finish at the 2036 Olympics?

Achieving a top 10 finish will require systemic reforms, increased investment in sports science, enhanced grassroots and talent identification programmes, improved infrastructure, and significant governance and policy overhauls.

How has your experience been as Sports Minister?

I am trying my best. Sport is a new area for me, but I am looking at a lot of things. I am focusing on sports science, nutrition, and engineering. I have noticed that while state governments allocate funds, there is often a lack of technical know-how, like how to build proper infrastructure, how to build and maintain a track. My focus will be to bridge this knowledge gap. We need to ensure that children get the best possible sports science, nutrition, and training from school level onwards.

There is immense potential in Indian athletes, but we need a long-term vision. Strengthening grassroots programmes, addressing governance issues, and promoting athlete welfare remain focal points. I am convinced that Indian sport has yet to truly realise and reap the benefits of women in sport — Nari Shakti.

Sport is not just about winning medals or getting a job through a sports quota. Today's generation is struggling with issues like depression and anxiety. Parents often say that their children are inactive and rarely leave the house. Sport can help tackle these problems. From sport, you can learn time management, fitness, teamwork, coordination, and so much more. We need to develop a culture in which sport is seen as a way of life — a path to building a healthier, happier society.